example, emissions data regulated by international treaties must align with stringent reporting standards, limiting the opportunity for manipulation.[6] Populists also think about their control over the domestic bureaucracy: Some leaders lack direct control over agencies that generate critical data, constraining their ability to manipulate or withhold information. In addition, leaders' time horizons matter. Strategies like ceasing data collection entirely may have longer-term consequences, as rebuilding capacity under a new government could take years. Withholding already collected data, by contrast, allows for quicker recovery when leadership changes.

The mix of tactics employed depends on a government's incentives, constraints, and strategic calculations. Compared with other anti-IO tactics, such as exiting institutions or creating competitor organizations, withholding information is generally faster and less costly. Regardless of the method chosen, the result is the same: IOs lose access to critical information, undermining their ability to fulfill their mandates.

4.2.2 IOs Fight Back: Information Sharing

When faced with gaps in critical information, IOs must quickly adapt to maintain their effectiveness. To replace the information lost when states under populist leadership withhold or distort data, IOs employ several strategies.

One approach involves leveraging open-source data or partnering with third parties, such as NGOs. However, while these sources can be useful, they often lack the granularity required for comprehensive analysis, and IOs may struggle to verify their accuracy independently. Another option is to turn to cooperative member states, particularly those with robust intelligence capabilities, advanced technologies, and sophisticated data systems. This solution, however, is limited by geopolitical considerations, the willingness, if any, of states to share sensitive information, and the availability of relevant data outside the IO's membership. States may possess detailed information on only a subset of members, such as allies, and may be hesitant to share other states' data.

A particularly effective method involves collaboration between IOs themselves. Each organization brings distinct expertise, infrastructure, and access to specialized data streams, making inter-IO cooperation a powerful